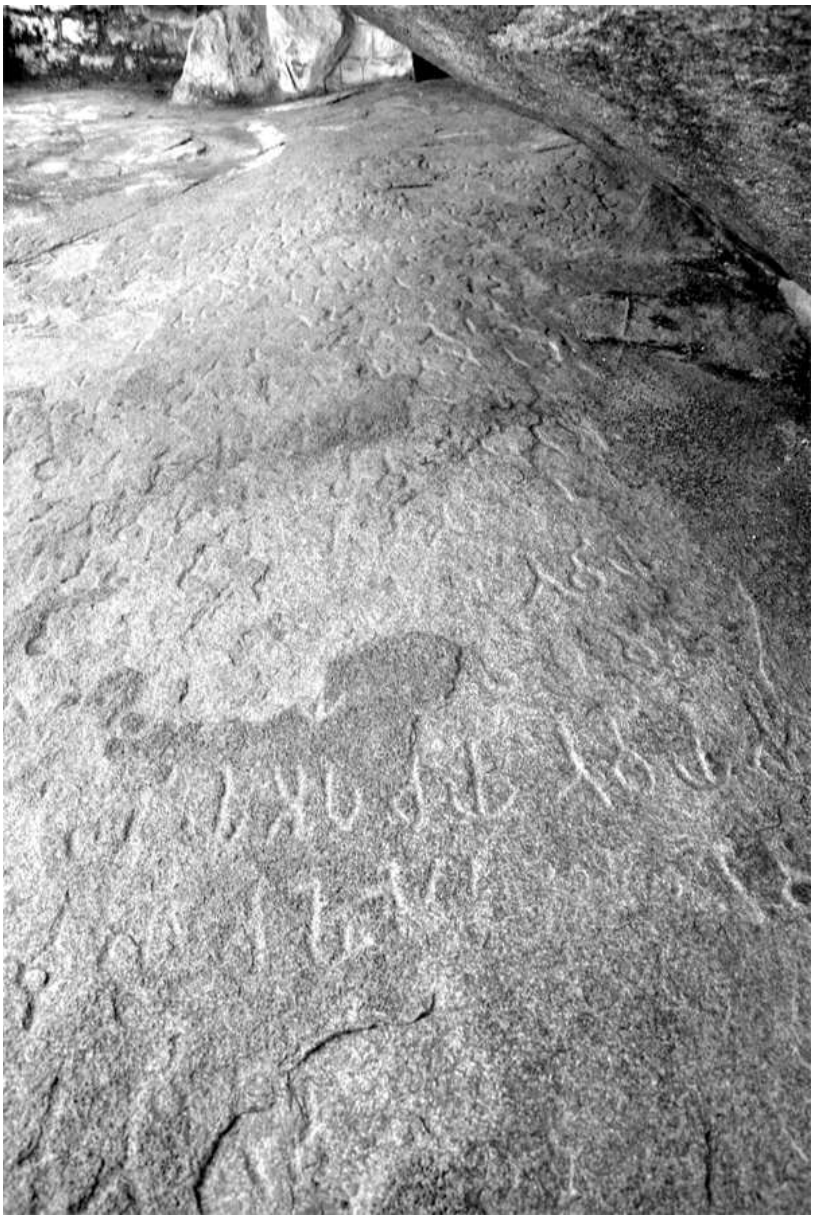


Fig. 6.6: Siddapura edict, cramped by the ledge above it

Considering how important it was for the emperor to communicate with his subjects, did local administrators appoint officials with rhetorical skills for the readings? Were there many such officials who could both read well and recite powerfully? Considering the oral culture of early India, it is very possible that even if this was a novel experience for Mauryan functionaries they would have attempted to render a public discourse by the emperor in a style similar to that deployed by poets addressing an audience of listeners.